

In fact, amateur photographers who would like to see hard copies of their photographs, the Canon iP3000 and 4000 will be the best and fastest bets.

For office users who primarily print sales brochures and other similar documents, these printers will do an extremely professional-looking job, and you will not have to keep negotiating with an outsourced printing firm for every brochure you would like to print.

Conclusion

After going through the various tests, Canon had done it again. This time, the iP3000 won, beating the iP4000 by an extremely small margin, primarily on account of its lower cost and lower running costs.

Special mention must be made of the Lexmark P915, as it came quite close to beating the Canon, but lost out mainly because of slow printing speeds and higher running cost. It is aimed at the home photo printing segment, and in that respect, it performs well enough and is competitively priced. If, for some reason, you would like to use this in an office setup, you can replace the photo cartridge with a black cartridge, which would reduce the running costs to a great extent.

Canon made a clean sweep this time round in both the home and office/photo segment, with their brand new Pixma range. Although the Lexmark came close in the office/photo segment, the iP1000 is far ahead of the competition with the HP 3745 scoring nearly 15 marks less. Canon has come and outdone them all—it's now time for the others to catch up!

MULTI-FUNCTION DEVICES

Installation

Although this department does not sway the overall scores much, we thought it worthwhile to mention it given our experiences at the Test Centre.

In today's plug-and-play era, one would expect much easier installation processes: the worst installers in this segment were HP's MFDs. Strangely, their printer installation was really smooth, but the MFD installer told us to wait as this could take 15-35 minutes depending on the system. On our test bed, it took us 20 minutes to install one MFD!

A close competitor for the HP on this front was Brother. The installation of their MFDs was cumbersome in terms of when to connect and when to disconnect, and then there was the waiting and the praying for it to get detected by the installer. More like plug-and-pray! On the other hand, the Epson and Lexmark installers were smooth.

For the rest of the testing, we divided the MFDs into two categories—office use and Photo MFDs.



Canon Pixma iP3000



Canon Pixma iP4000

Office MFDs

This category consisted of eight MFDs, and the usage pattern assumed during testing was that of a regular SoHo, with emphasis on performance, features and running cost and not so much on the initial cost.

Features And Build Quality

All the MFDs we received came with LCD panels except for the Epson CX 1500. Some of the LCDs were decidedly better than the others. The Brother LCDs were the single line, B&W variety, and the contrast was so abysmal that we had to literally move around to get a reasonable viewing angle and read what the screen said. The Lexmark P6250 was the sleekest-looking device, and looked identical to the P915 printer. Other devices, such as the HP 5510 and the Lexmark X7170, came with ADF. None of the Epsoms were equipped with dial pads for faxing, and this was also missing on the HP 1608.

All the MFDs supporting fax came bundled with telephone wires. Some MFDs, such as the HP 4255, even had standard RJ45 sockets to connect them to a network—an extremely useful feature for a SoHo setup.

Score Board for Inkjet Printers

Device	Interpolated Resolution	Type of cartridges	PictBridge/Mem. Card Reader	Tray Capacity (In/out)	LCD Screen/ Type	Overall Score (Out of 100)	Price (Rs)
Home Printers							
Canon Pixma iP1000	4800x1200	B/W and Color	No/No	150/No Out Tray	No/NA	56.37	3195
HP Deskjet 3745	1200x1200	B/W and Color	No/No	80/50	No/NA	41.56	2999
HP Deskjet 3845	1200x1200	B/W and Color	No/No	100/50	No/NA	37.94	3999
Epson Stylus C45	2880x720	B/W and Color	No/No	100/50	No/NA	40.24	3295
Office/Photo Printers							
Canon iP1500	4800x1200	B/W and Color	No/No	150/No Out Tray	No/NA	42.84	4495
Canon iP2000	4800x1200	B/W and Color	Yes/No	300/NA	No/NA	53.17	6495
Canon iP3000	4800x1200	CMYK (4)	Yes/No	300/NA	No/NA	60.39	8495
Canon iP4000	4800x1200	CMYK (6)	Yes/No	300/NA	No/NA	59.1	10995
Epson Photo R210	5760x1440	CMYK (6)	Yes/No	120/80	No/NA	38.77	9895
Epson Photo R310	5760x1440	CMYK (6)	Yes/Yes	120/80	Yes/B/W	51.94	13495
HP Deskjet 5748	4800x1200	B/W and Color	No/No	100/50	No/NA	39.07	5999
Lexmark P915	4800x1200	Photo/Color(2)	Yes/Yes	100/70	Yes/Color	55.81	8999

For the complete scoreboard, log on to www.thinkdigit.com